



Work overload and intimidation: The moderating role of resilience

Takuma Kimura^{a,*}, Belén Bande^b, Pilar Fernández-Ferrín^c

^a Hosei University, 2-17-1, Fujimi, Chiyoda-ku, Tokyo, Japan

^b University of Navarra, Facultad de Económicas, Campus Universitario, 31080 Pamplona, Spain

^c University of País Vasco (UPV/EHU), EU Estudios Empresariales, Comandante Izarduy, 23 01006 Vitoria-Gasteiz, Spain

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ABSTRACT

Work overload is a critical but understudied stressor at work, particularly for boundary-spanning positions. Recent studies have highlighted the need for more research on the identification of different predictors of the use of intimidation, a type of assertive impression management tactic. Relying on Lazarus's transactional theory, this study hypothesized and investigated a mediated moderation model that includes resilience, work overload, and its outcomes.

This paper contributes to the organizational literature by examining the use of intimidation by salespeople as a reaction to stressful circumstances and the association between this tactic and salespeople's performance. The information provided by 248 employee–supervisor dyads confirmed the proposed model. Work overload has a positive association with intimidation, and the direct effect of work overload on intimidation depends on the level of an employee's resilience. Finally, the use of intimidation has a negative association with supervisor-rated performance.

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1. Introduction

The literature on impression management has long recognized that intimidation is a typical form of impression management behavior (Bolino, Kacmar, Turnley, & Gilstrap, 2008; Bolino, Long, & Turnley, 2016; Jones & Pittman, 1982). Intimidation is an assertive impression management (IM) tactic characterized by the strategic use of interpersonal force to indicate one's power and obtain behavioral acquiescence to create desired images in the minds of others (Bolino & Turnley, 1999, 2003; Jones & Pittman, 1982).

Empirical studies have shown the negative effects of intimidation, suggesting its seriousness as a workplace deviant behavior. For example, Falbe and Yukl (1992) revealed that intimidation has negative influences on coworkers' work attitudes (Falbe & Yukl, 1992). Anecdotal evidence also suggests the seriousness of the negative effects of intimidation. According to Asian Women at Work Action Group (2008), in some cases, intimidation takes the form of assigning an excessive amount of work, and in other cases, it causes work overload. For example, some managers intimidate their subordinates by forcing them to complete a large amount of

work with few members or assigning work of great physical difficulty. In addition, the International Labor Organization (ILO) reported that workplace violence including intimidation causes musculoskeletal disorders in the targets—which is the focus of considerable attention in recent occupational safety and health practices (ILO 2016). A recent empirical study revealed that this process is mediated by psychological strain (Vignoli, Guglielmi, Balducci, & Bonfiglioli, 2015).

While anecdotal evidence and empirical findings suggest that intimidation is a work-related stressor for targets, other streams of research revealed that individuals' work stress induces their intimidation (Samnani & Singh, 2012, for a review). These findings indicate that work stressors and intimidation can bring about a vicious cycle where work stressors can induce the use of intimidation, and then the intimidation becomes a stressor for the targets.

Among the various work stressors, work overload has attracted considerable research attention in the management field (Ganster & Rosen, 2013). Work overload occurs when workload and time pressures exceed employees' abilities to perform their jobs (Kahn, Wolfe, Quinn, Snoek, & Rosenthal, 1964). A meta-analysis by Gilboa and colleagues showed that work overload is significantly associated with job performance (Gilboa, Shirom, Fried, & Cooper, 2008). Their analysis also showed that in studies published in the first-tier journals, work overload predicts job performance more

* Corresponding author.

E-mail addresses: ktakuma@hosei.ac.jp (T. Kimura), bbande@unav.es (B. Bande), pilar.fernandezf@ehu.es (P. Fernández-Ferrín).

strongly than role ambiguity—another major stressor in workplaces. From a practical viewpoint, also, work overload is a notable issue. For example, ILO refers to work overload as a major work stressor and a major cause of impaired mental health (ILO, 2016). Thus, it is important to investigate the association between work overload and the use of intimidation.

If the association between work overload and intimidation is significant, the investigation of the moderating factors that can attenuate the impact of work overload is also important. According to Lazarus's transactional theory (Lazarus, 1991), individuals' self-rated personal resources moderate the negative effect of work overload. As Bakker and Demerouti (2014) noted, while empirical studies have paid much attention to the moderating effects of job resources, evidence for the interaction between personal resources and job demands is limited. Personal resources include individuals' sense of their ability to successfully control and impact their environment, especially during challenging circumstances (Hobfoll, Johnson, Ennis, & Jackson, 2003).

Although we recognize that a variety of personal resources can attenuate the negative effects of work overload, in this study, we focus on resilience. Resilience, which is understood as the ability to rebound strengthened with more resources, protects individuals from the psychological damage associated with adversity and increases the likelihood that they will resolve challenging situations adequately (Block & Kremen, 1996). Researchers in developmental and educational psychology emphasized that resilience contains self-regulatory functions that serve to buffer the negative effects of an undesirable environment and prevent one from engaging in deviant behaviors (Buckner, Mezzacappa, & Beardslee, 2003; Gardner, Dishion, & Connell, 2008). Self-regulation is an internal and/or transactional process that enables an individual to guide his/her goal-directed activities over time and across changing circumstances (Karoly, 1993). Gardner et al. (2008) regarded resilience as position adaptation in the face of heightened risk for maladaptation and argued that such adaptation requires the actor's self-regulation. The self-regulatory aspect of resilience can also be assumed in business settings, but few studies in the management field have dealt with it. Thus, it is meaningful to propose and examine the moderating effect of resilience on the effect of an undesirable environment (work overload) on intimidation (deviant behavior).

In addition, we propose and test the influence of work overload and intimidation on sales performance. Specifically, we examine the direct effect of work overload and its indirect effect through intimidation. For the direct effect, we rely on Lazarus's transactional theory and assume that work overload substantially lowers the level of performance. We also assume that this negative effect of work overload is moderated by resilience. Regarding the indirect effect, relying on empirical evidence in the field of impression management, we surmise that an employee who engages in intimidation is likely to be evaluated low by his/her supervisors because of his/her unfavorable image generated by their use of intimidation (Bolino & Turnley, 2003). To test these ideas, we propose the model depicted in Fig. 1.

This study makes several contributions to the theory and research. First, we explore the antecedents and consequences of intimidation, which is an under-researched tactic (Bolino et al., 2008). Whereas there is a great deal of research about ingratiation or supervisor-focused tactics and self-promotion or job-focused tactics (Tedeschi & Melburg, 1984), intimidation has been addressed far less frequently and is not as well understood (Harris, Gallagher, & Rossi, 2013), especially its predictors and consequences (e.g., Harris et al., 2013; Whitaker & Dahling, 2013). For example, it has been noted that the association of intimidation—performance evaluation is poorly understood, and

the findings are inconsistent (Bolino et al., 2008). Second, this study attends to calls for research on the factors that mitigate the influence of work stressors on outcomes (Örtqvist & Wincent, 2006) by examining the moderating effect of individuals' resilience on the association between work overload and the use of intimidation. Finally, as Coleman Gallagher, Harris, and Valle (2008) note, little is known about how intimidation is used or how it is received in various countries and cultures. We conducted our research in Spain, a country with cultural dimensions that differ substantially from those of the United States, which is the context that has been considered in most published studies.

2. Theoretical foundations and hypothesis development

2.1. Transactional theory

The transactional theory of stress (Lazarus & Folkman, 1984; Lazarus, 1991) proposes that the individual's reaction to stress comprises two steps: primary appraisal and secondary appraisal. Primary appraisal is one's perceptive assessment of the degree to which a particular stressor poses a threat to self, and secondary appraisal is one's assessment of the controllability of the stressor and his/her coping resources. The basic assumption of this theory is that a stressor leads to strain only when the perceived threat to the self exceeds one's perceived level of coping resources.

The theory suggests that when individuals perceive that they have sufficient personal resources, they do not feel a strain. On the other hand, when individuals perceive that their personal resources for coping are insufficient, they experience a strain and thus engage in a coping strategy. One of the components of coping is dealing with the problem that causes the stress (problem-focused coping). Intimidation would be an example of these coping strategies, where the employee confronts sources of stress with active attempts to alter the situation and solve the problem. According to the classification of job strains suggested by Jex and Beehr (1991), intimidation can be regarded as a type of behavioral strain, which is a means for individuals to cope with stressors either by eliminating the stressor or by reducing the negative emotions elicited by it (Penney & Spector, 2005). Bolino and Turnley (2003: 238) describe intimidation as an individual's strategy to "let others know that they can make things difficult for them if they are pushed too far, deal aggressively with individuals who get in their way, or use forceful behavior to get colleagues to behave appropriately." They further argued that individuals who use intimidation may also generate aversion or dislike in the process (Bolino & Turnley, 2003, p. 238).

2.2. Work overload and intimidation

Scholars in the field of work stress have regarded work overload as one of the major stressors in workplaces (e.g., Frone, 2008; Jex & Bliese, 1999). Work overload appears when employees feel that there are too many responsibilities or activities expected of them considering the time available, their abilities, and other constraints (Rizzo, House, & Lirtzman, 1970). In Örtqvist and Wincent's (2006) meta-analysis, overload was associated with reduced organizational commitment and job satisfaction and increased depersonalization and emotional exhaustion. In addition, work overload has been identified as a critical predictor of turnover intentions and job performance (Babakus, Yavas, & Ashill, 2009; Mulki, Lassk, & Jaramillo, 2008).

As we noted earlier, transactional theory suggests that when a perceived threat to the self exceeds one's perceived level of coping resources, a stressor generates stress reactions including behavioral strain. Mayes and Ganster (1988) argued that stress causes negative

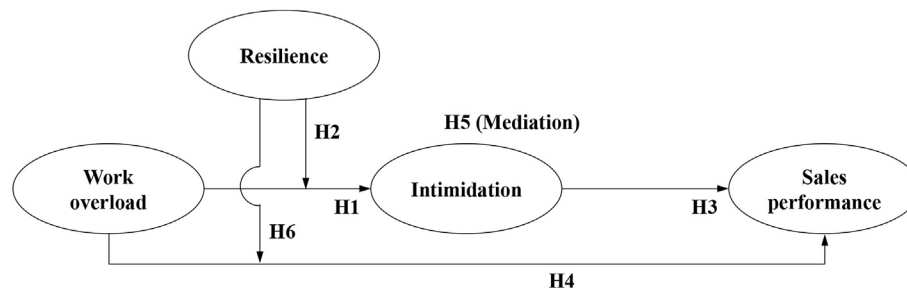


Fig. 1. Proposed model.

behavioral responses and that some individuals exhibit a fight response in reaction to psychological threats when they feel fear or stress. Coleman Gallagher et al. (2008) noted that this response can assume the form of aggressive workplace behaviors such as intimidation.

General strain theory suggests that when faced with a high level of work stressor, a person engages in deviant behavior to escape from, avoid, terminate, or alleviate the negative stimulus (Agnew, 1992). Previous studies showed that work stressors such as frustrating events and work overload induce employees' deviant behavior such as aggression and bullying (Baillien, De Cuyper, & De Witte, 2011; Fox & Spector, 1999). These deviant behaviors are used as measures to relieve oneself from the strain (Baillien et al., 2011).

Moreover, there is evidence that perceptions of excessive workload can cause anger and irritation (e.g., Fox, Spector, & Miles, 2001), and individuals who hold such perceptions can release their negative emotions by being rude to others. As Lee and Allen (2002) stated, hostility has a strong correlation with workplace deviance; that is, a set of behaviors that might be perceived by many as improper or outside normal conventions of acceptability. According to Bennett and Robinson (2000), "acting rudely toward someone at work" is an example of such behaviors. The findings of prior studies suggest that work overload results in the use of intimidation. For example, Coleman Gallagher et al. (2008) found a positive association between job tension and the use of intimidation in the workplace.

Based on the above discussion, we state the following hypothesis:

Hypothesis 1. Work overload has a positive association with the use of intimidation.

2.3. Resilience as a moderator of the relationship between work overload and intimidation

Based on the tenet of Lazarus's (1991) transactional theory, we examine perceived resilience (i.e., self-rated resilience) as a moderator of the relationship between work overload and intimidation. Resilience is an incipient area of research in the work domain (Sommer, Howell, & Hadley, 2016; Stajkovic, 2006). In fact, much of what we know about resilience in organizations to date is extrapolated from the fields of child development and psychodynamics (Sommer et al., 2016).

Regarding its conceptualization, there is a lack of a universally accepted definition of resilience in the literature (Aburn, Gott, & Hoare, 2016). Traditionally, psychologists have regarded resilience as an individual trait, but recent studies—in particular, those in the field of positive organizational behavior (Luthans, Avolio, Avey, & Norman, 2007)—have regarded it as a capacity that can be enhanced (Kossek & Perrigino, 2016). Based on empirical findings that show the malleability of resilience and recent arguments on its

implication for human resource development (Avey, Luthans, & Jensen, 2009; Kossek & Perrigino, 2016), in this study, we adopt a perspective that conceptualizes resilience as a capacity that can be developed. Therefore, in the conceptualization of resilience, we rely on the definition by Stewart, Reid, and Mangham (1997: 22), who described it as "the capability of individuals to cope successfully in the face of change, adversity, and risk." In line with Edward, Welch, and Chater (2009), and Kumpfer (1999), we consider the ability to bounce back as a key component of understanding resilience. Regarding its nature, resilience is a state-like attribute (Rutter, 1985) that can be developed and that contributes—along with other factors such as self-efficacy, optimism, and hope—to higher order constructs such as "positive psychological capital" (Luthans et al., 2007) or "core confidence" (Stajkovic, 2006).

Resilience promotes the recognition and acknowledgment of the destructive impact that overwhelming events can have, thereby "allowing the affected individual the time, energy, and resource investment to recover, rebound, and return to an equilibrium point" (Youssef & Luthans, 2007, p. 780). Accordingly, perceived resilience can be regarded as a type of self-rated coping resource. Thus, in the face of an adverse work environment, individuals who believe that they are resilient are likely to perceive that they have sufficient coping resources for dealing with the adversity. On the other hand, individuals who regard themselves as not resilient are likely to perceive that they lack coping resources. Consistent with this argument, empirical studies have shown that perceived resilience has a negative association with stress-related anxiety (Krush & Agnihotri, 2013) and emotional exhaustion (Bande, Fernández-Ferrín, Varela, & Jaramillo, 2015). Therefore, we expect that one's perceived resilience will help lessen the positive impact of work overload on the use of intimidation as a behavioral strain.

As we conceptualize resilience as a capacity rather than a process (Kossek & Perrigino, 2016), we assume that it works as a moderator rather than mediator for the effect of work overload. Specifically, we assume that resilience as a process of coping with adversity (Richardson, 2002) could be influenced by work overload, but one's malleable ability to bounce back (i.e., resilience as a capacity) may not be directly enhanced or deteriorated by work overload. Rather, resilience as a capacity will work as a moderator that attenuates the negative effects of work overload.

Therefore, we propose the following:

Hypothesis 2. Perceived resilience moderates the positive association between work overload and the use of intimidation such that the relationship is weaker for salespersons who report a higher level of perceived resilience than for those who report a lower level.

2.4. Intimidation and performance

There is evidence that the performance appraisal process is often influenced by the impression management behavior of

employees (Bolino & Turnley, 2003; Ferris, Judge, Rowland, & Fitzgibbons, 1994; Wayne & Liden, 1995). Previous research has suggested that some individuals use intimidation as an impression management tactic in the workplace (Bolino et al., 2008). These behaviors can successfully generate favorable evaluations from others (e.g., Wayne, Liden, Graf, & Ferris, 1997) because intimidators may leave observers with the impression that they are powerful, capable, and efficient (Friedland, 1976). However, the potential for intimidation to backfire seems to be particularly great (Harris et al., 2013; Jones, 1990). In this vein, intimidation can lead to long-term negative career consequences such as fewer opportunities for promotion and less career success (Maccoby, Gittell, & Ledeen, 2004).

Intimidation is an assertive IM tactic that employs threats or harassment in an attempt to appear dangerous and powerful (Bolino et al., 2008). As Bolino and Turnley (2003) suggest, contemporary organizations tend to stress teamwork and cohesiveness, and in such environments, individuals who intimidate and threaten others may be considered more a liability than an asset and thus be given lower performance ratings. Similarly, researchers suggest that individuals are often angry with and resentful of others who try to manipulate and intimidate them (Yukl & Tracey, 1992). Additionally, as shown by Zanzi and O'Neill (2001), people tend to regard intimidation as a nonsanctioned political behavior that deviates from organizational norms. Accordingly, supervisors can understand the negative influence of such behaviors on the social context of the broader organization and may regard subordinates' use of intimidation as deviating from the requirements of a work role.

Therefore, we propose the following:

Hypothesis 3. The use of intimidation has a negative association with supervisor-rated employee performance.

Relying on the transactional theory of stress (Lazarus & Folkman, 1984), Gilboa et al. (2008) suggested three mechanisms through which work stressors have a negative effect on job performance. First, when employees perceive a potentially threatening or eventually harmful stressor, they will use up energy and time to cope with it. Second, high levels of stressors are associated with involuntary physiological responses that interfere with performance. Third, high levels of stressors tend to cause information overload, which in turn narrows individuals' perceptual attention so that they ignore performance-related information and cues. The meta-analysis by Gilboa et al. (2008) supported these arguments, showing the significant negative relationship between overload—"role overload" in their study—and job performance. Therefore, we propose the following:

Hypothesis 4. Work overload has a negative association with supervisor-rated employee performance.

We also assume an indirect path. Combining the arguments of hypothesis 1 and hypothesis 3, we assume that work overload promotes employees' use of intimidation and thereby has negative effects on supervisor-rated performance. Relying on general strain theory, Agnew, Piquero, and Cullen (2009) argued that when faced with a high level of work overload, employees might engage in criminal behavior even though such behavior obviously has detrimental effects on their life. In a study of intimidation, Coleman Gallagher et al. (2008) argued that in spite of the potential negative effects on their career in the long-term, individuals who faced with a high level of job tension choose to use intimidation to alleviate the immediate job tension in the short term. These arguments suggest the mediating role of intimidation in the relationship between job tension and career outcomes, but empirical

evidence has not been offered. Thus the mediating role of intimidation can be expected and worthy of being empirically tested. Therefore, although we admit that intimidation is not the only mediator of the relationship between work overload and performance, we propose the following mediation hypothesis.

Hypothesis 5. The use of intimidation partially mediates the relationship between work overload and sales performance. Specifically, work overload has positive effects on the use of intimidation, and then the use of intimidation has negative effects on the supervisor-rated sales performance.

2.5. Resilience as a moderator of the relationship between work overload and performance

We also assume that the impact of work overload on employee performance is attenuated by resilience. Resilience is the capacity to rebound or bounce back from adversity and work as a resource to navigate a stressful workplace (Avey et al., 2009; Luthans et al., 2007). Resilience enables one to be tolerant to large workload, thus making someone less likely to deplete personal resources to implement their work roles. Employees who regard themselves as resilient are likely to perceive that they have sufficient resources for dealing with the workload. Thus, they are likely to be able to concentrate their attention on their role without anxiety. Therefore, we propose the following:

Hypothesis 6. Perceived resilience moderates the positive relationship between work overload and supervisor-rated employee performance such that the relationship is weaker for salespersons who report a higher level of perceived resilience than for those who report a lower level.

3. Method

3.1. Participants and procedure

To test our model, we conducted a quantitative analysis of a questionnaire survey using a supervisor–salespeople matching sample. To ensure adequate representation of salespeople, we recruited respondents from various firms in different industries. First, we contacted 163 companies located in Spain. The organizations were selected on the basis of their commercial recognition and of the fact that they were primarily serving business customers. Of the 163 companies, 145 agreed to participate in the study. They covered a variety of industries including construction, technology, financial services, manufacturing, wholesale, and insurance. The information was collected through personal interviews with the help of each organization's human resource or commercial department. The final sample consisted of 248 matched supervisor–salesperson dyads, which included 248 salespeople and 145 supervisors. No incentive was provided to participate.

The demographic characteristics of the sample were as follows. Most of the salespeople were men (71.9 percent), with an average age of 38.9 years ($SD = 8.3$) and an average organizational tenure of 11 years ($SD = 7.9$). Of the supervisors, 83.4 percent were male, the average age was 45.3 years ($SD = 10.3$), and the average organizational tenure was 13.8 years ($SD = 12.1$).

3.2. Measures

The survey instrument was initially written in English and then translated into Spanish using the back-translation procedure (Brislin, 1986). The translated Spanish version questionnaire was

pre-tested on several experts who were asked to comment on items that they found confusing or difficult to understand. In addition, as a trial response, the questionnaire was distributed to ten supervisor–salesperson dyads belonging to ten companies from different sectors. As a result of these tests, some items were modified to improve clarity and comprehension.

All the items were measured on a seven-point Likert scale (1 = totally disagree; 7 = totally agree). Employees provided information regarding work overload, resilience, and intimidation, while their direct supervisors provided information regarding their subordinates' sales performance.

Work overload. We assessed work overload with the five-item scale developed by Roberts, Lapidus, & Chonko, 1997. Sample items include “I have an excessive workload” and “I am required to attend too many meetings.” The Cronbach's alpha for this scale was .90, and the composite reliability was .89.

Intimidation. The use of intimidation was measured with a five-item scale from Bolino and Turnley (1999). Sample items include “Be intimidating with coworkers when it will help you get your job done” and “Deal strongly or aggressively with coworkers who interfere in your business.” The Cronbach's alpha for this scale was .92, and the composite reliability was .92.

Perceived resilience. We measured salespeople's perceived resilience with three items adapted from the Brief Resilience Scale developed by Smith et al. (2008). Sample items include “I tend to bounce back quickly after hard times” and “It does not take me long to recover from a stressful event.” The Cronbach's alpha for this scale was .67, and the composite reliability was .67.

Sales performance. Each salesperson's performance was measured by their supervisor using a nine-item scale developed by Griffin, Neal, and Parker (2007). This scale assesses whether the employee fulfills the prescribed requirements of the job by contributing to individual, team, and organization effectiveness. It comprises three items for Individual Task Proficiency (ITP), three items for Team Member Proficiency (TMP), and three items for Organization Member Proficiency (OMP). Sample items were “Carried out the core parts of his job well” (ITP), “Coordinated his work with coworkers” (TMP), and “Presented a positive image of the organization to other people” (OMP). The Cronbach's alphas for each dimension were .86 (ITP), .84 (TMP), and .87 (OMP), while the composite reliabilities were, respectively, .86, .84, and .87.

Control variables. Previous studies showed correlations between some demographic variables and individuals' use of IM. For example, Coleman Gallagher et al. (2008) showed that male workers are more likely than female workers to use intimidation. As another example, Baillien et al. (2011) reported a negative correlation between age and engaging in workplace bullying. Therefore, the salesperson age and gender (0 = male, 1 = female) were considered as control variables.

Before testing the hypothesized model, we conducted confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) using AMOS software. The maximum likelihood (ML) estimation method was employed to estimate the parameters of the latent constructs. The results suggest an acceptable fit: $\chi^2 = 355.35$; $df = 197$; $p < 0.01$; $\chi^2/df = 1.80$; RMSEA = 0.05; TLI = 0.95; CFI = 0.95; IFI = 0.95. All the lambda parameters were significant ($p < 0.01$) and greater than 0.5, hence supporting convergent validity.

We followed Fornell and Larcker's (1981) recommendation to assess the discriminant validity. None of the confidence intervals for the correlations between pairs of constructs included the value one; hence, the discriminant validity was assumed. In addition, the AVE square root of each variable was higher than the squared correlation with all other constructs. Thus, we can say that the discriminant validity of the measures was at a sufficient level.

4. Results

4.1. Descriptive statistics

The means, standard deviations, and correlations for all the variables included in this study are provided in Table 1. It shows that gender has a negative and moderate correlation with resilience, demonstrating that in our sample, male salespeople are more likely to perceive themselves resilient than female salespeople. It also shows that work overload and the use of intimidation has a positive correlation, as we proposed in hypothesis 1. Moreover, consistent with hypothesis 3, the use of intimidation has a negative correlation with all three dimensions of sales performance.

4.2. Hypothesis testing

To test the proposed hypotheses, we conducted a conditional process analysis using the PROCESS Procedure for SPSS Release 2.16 (Model 8: Hayes, 2013). Salesperson age and gender were included as control variables in these analyses. To avoid interpretation problems with some of the coefficients, we proceed to mean center the variables involved in the interaction terms (work overload and resilience). The results of the analysis using ordinary least squares (OLS) reveal that the interaction between overload and resilience is not significantly associated with performance ($c'_3 = .02$, $p = .51$); thus, hypothesis 6 was not supported. According to Hayes (2013: 396), when an interaction term is not significant, “parsimony might dictate that your model should be cleansed of this interaction.” Accordingly, we proceed to redefine and test again our theoretical model, eliminating the moderating effect of resilience on the relationship between overload and performance.

The results of the analysis using OLS (Model 7: Hayes, 2013) are shown in Table 2. First, overload has a positive and significant influence on the use of intimidation ($a_1 = .41$, $p < .001$), which in turn has a negative and significant effect on performance ($b = -.09$, $p = .04$). Thus, hypotheses 1 and 3 were supported. In addition, the results reveal a direct and negative effect of work overload on salesperson performance ($c' = -.10$, $p < .01$), confirming hypothesis 4. Thus, these findings show that part of the work overload effect on performance occurs independently of intimidation.

In addition, the results show that the positive relationship between work overload and intimidation is contingent on salesperson resilience, as evidenced by the statistically significant effect of the interaction between work overload and resilience on intimidation ($a_3 = -.12$, $p = .02$). Thus, hypothesis 2 was supported.

To probe the moderating effect of resilience on the relationship between work overload and intimidation and to make statistical inferences about the conditional indirect effects, the pick-a-point method (Rogosa, 1980) combined with bootstrapping is used, which is a highly recommended technique (Hayes, 2013; Malhotra, Singhal, Shang, & Ployhart, 2014). In Table 3, we include the indirect conditional effects of overload on sales performance for various values of resilience and the bias-corrected bootstrap confidence intervals for these effects. We observe that the indirect effect is always negative, and the confidence intervals do not contain zero, thus supporting hypothesis 5. However, the indirect effect of work overload on sales performance through intimidation is not constant because it depends on resilience, which again supports hypothesis 2. The higher the resilience is, the weaker the negative effect of work overload on sales performance.

The relationship between work overload and intimidation is plotted for high- and low-resilience individuals (defined as +1 and -1 standard deviation from the mean, respectively; Aiken, West & Reno, 1991) (see Fig. 2). The simple slope test showed that the regression coefficient of intimidation onto work overload

Table 1
Correlation matrix.

	Mean	SD	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
1. Gender ^a	0.25	0.43	—							
2. Age	38.98	8.34	−0.20**	—						
3. Overload	3.67	1.59	0.05	−0.12	—					
4. Intimidation	2.27	1.31	−0.01	−0.03	0.47**	—				
5. Resilience	5.26	0.95	−0.16**	−0.11	−0.09	−0.15*	—			
6. ITP	5.78	0.96	0.07	0.07	−0.23**	−0.17**	0.08	—		
7. TMP	5.70	1.06	0.07	0.06	−0.16**	−0.14*	0.08	0.62**	—	
8. OMP	5.83	0.95	0.02	0.18**	−0.31**	−0.30**	0.13*	0.62**	0.58**	—

Notes: * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$.

a: 0 = man; 1 = woman.

Point-biserial correlations computed for the correlation between gender (dichotomous) and the other variables (numerical).

Table 2
Model coefficients for the conditional process model.

Antecedents	M (Intimidation)			Y (Performance)		
	Coeff.	SE	p	Coeff.	SE	p
Constant	2.42	0.45	<.001	5.26	0.33	<.001
Overload	0.41	0.04	<.001	−0.10	0.03	<.01
Resilience	−0.25	0.08	<.01	—	—	—
Overload x resilience	−0.12	0.05	<.05	—	—	—
Intimidation	—	—	—	−0.09	0.04	.04
<i>Controls</i>						
Age	0.001	0.009	.89	0.01	0.006	.06
Gender	−0.16	0.17	.35	0.19	0.12	.10
	$R^2 = 0.25$, $F(5,242) = 16.51$ $p < .001$			$R^2 = 0.11$, $F(4,243) = 7.43$, $p < .001$		

Table 3
Direct and indirect effects of overload on intimidation.

Conditional indirect effects of overload on performance through intimidation at values of resilience				
Resilience	Indirect effect	BootSE	BootLLCI	BootULCI
4.0000	−.0517	.0262	−.1040	−.0015
4.6667	−.0442	.0222	−.0883	−.0013
5.3333	−.0366	.0186	−.0740	−.0010
6.0000	−.0291	.0158	−.0636	−.0008
6.6667	−.0215	.0142	−.0555	−.0002
Unconditional direct effect of work overload on performance				
Direct effect	SE	P	LLCI	ULCI
−.10	0.03	<.01	−.18	−.03

^aValues are for the 10th, 25th, 50th, 75th, and 90th percentiles.

for high-resilience employees was .29 ($t = 5.92$, $p < .001$), while that for low-resilience employees was .53 ($t = 7.70$, $p < .001$). Thus, consistent with [hypothesis 2](#), the relationship between overload and intimidation was positive and stronger for low-resilience salespeople, while for high-resilience individuals, the relationship was positive but much weaker.

Overall, the results supported our hypothesized model. We found that work overload had a negative association with performance, both directly and indirectly, through intimidation. In addition, this indirect effect is conditional, as it depends on the salesperson's perceived resilience. This means that an employee's perceived ability to bounce back buffers the indirect negative effect of overload on performance by reducing the positive effect of work overload on the use of intimidation. No significant effects of the control variables on the dependent variables were found.

5. Discussion

Previous studies on influence tactics and political behavior have recognized that undesirable types of behavior such as intimidation are prevalent in workplaces and that supervisors and employees regard such behavior as deviant. However, we do not have sufficient knowledge of why employees use such undesirable means of influence behavior and how to prevent organizational members from engaging in such behavior. Examining a model that includes intimidation as a mediator, this study partly responds to a recent call for more research on the antecedents and consequences of intimidation ([Harris et al., 2013](#); [Whitaker & Dahling, 2013](#)). Instead of focusing on employees' morality and other stable personality traits, we put our focus on a situational factor (i.e., work overload) and malleable individual ability (i.e., resilience). Our findings on the moderating effects of resilience partly respond to calls for research on the factors that attenuate the negative effects of work stressors ([Bakker & Demerouti, 2014](#); [Örtqvist & Wincent, 2006](#)).

The results of the present study are consistent with the predictions of general strain theory, transactional theory, and the IM literature. General strain theory assumes that a stressor induces deviant behavior through the generation of negative emotions. Work stressors such as work overload can trigger employees' hostility and anger, which can manifest in acting rudely toward others ([Chen & Spector, 1992](#)). Thus, intimidation can be considered as a behavioral reaction to environmental demands and threats.

As for the effectiveness of this IM tactic, our findings show that the use of a hard tactic such as intimidation has negative effects on employee performance appraisals. Our result aligns with previous studies that have confirmed that intimidation can definitely backfire ([Thacker & Wayne, 1995](#); [Turnley & Bolino, 2001](#)). According to [Yukl and Tracey \(1992\)](#), intimidation is often considered as socially undesirable. Therefore, our findings suggest the possibility that intimidation can backfire because it can be considered as a form of counterproductive behavior that is improper and outside normal conventions or acceptability.

While our analysis showed a moderating effect of resilience on the relationship between work overload and the use of intimidation, it did not show a moderating effect of resilience on the relationship between work overload and sales performance, which means that the performance problem generated by work overload cannot be fully resolved by individuals' resilience. The direct path from work overload suggested the possibility that work overload substantially reduces one's level of performance by depleting his/her cognitive, physical, and affective resources. Our results suggest that although resilience can work as a resource to prevent individuals from engaging in intimidation, its function is not sufficient for dealing with resource depletion caused by work overload. For instance, resilient individuals are less likely to feel stress in the face of work overload and thus are less likely to resort to

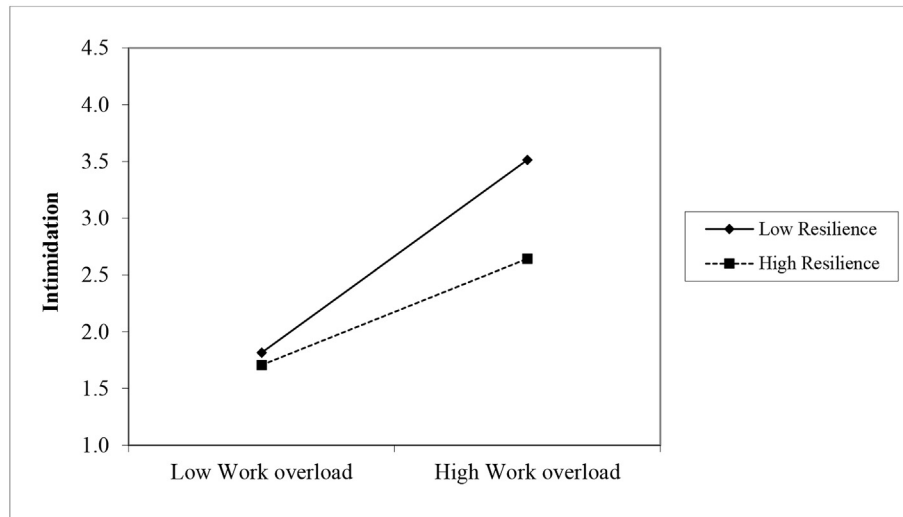


Fig. 2. Conditional effects of work overload on intimidation.

intimidation. However, information overload associated with work overload cannot be reduced by resilience, and therefore, it prevents an individual from paying sufficient attention to performance-related information and cues.

Our findings advance the literature on IM in several respects. First, considering the shortage of research on intimidation within the organizational context, our results illustrate that the use of intimidation tactics is a consequence of stressful workplace conditions. This finding might be an explanation of why people tend to use intimidation more frequently than they think is socially desirable (Zanzi & O'Neill, 2001).

Second, we investigated the role of a salesperson's ability to bounce back as a possible moderator in the relationship between work overload and the use of hostile influence tactics such as intimidation. In this regard, our results underscore the importance of considering the influence of personal resources on the use of intimidation tactics and, in particular, the role of resilience as an inhibitor of negative responses.

Moreover, our findings underscore the value of understanding resilience within the organizational context. The direct effect of work overload on the use of intimidation by salespeople is also positive but not constant, as it depends on the level of an employee's perceived resilience. The greater the perceived ability to bounce back, the weaker the effect of work overload on intimidation. This result is consistent with the tenet of transactional theory. Specifically, individuals who perceive that they are high in resilience are likely to feel that they can overcome the threat of work demands when they are faced with work overload. Meanwhile, individuals who perceive that they are low in resilience are likely to be overwhelmed by the threat of work overload and thus fall into strain reactions. Overall, this study highlights the idea that what matters is not what occurs, but rather how one responds to what occurs (Coutu, 2002; Hunter & Chandler, 1999).

Resilience is a protective factor that can buffer the relationship between risk factors (i.e., work overload) and negative outcomes (i.e., the use of hard influence tactics). As Hao, Hong, Xu, Zhou, and Xie (2015) state, highly resilient individuals are more confident and able to react to stress, and they are more adept at using the surrounding supporting resources. Our findings are consistent with the notion that resilience helps individuals cope with adversity and achieve good adjustment and development (Hu, Zhang, & Wang, 2015). Regarding the specific nature of sales positions, our results

complement previous research (i.e., Krush & Agnihotri, 2013) and confirm that resilience, which is considered malleable and open to development, is an important personal resource in the competitive and increasingly complex environment that salespeople confront today. Moreover, our finding of the moderating effect of resilience might be an explanation for the previous finding of a weak relationship between work stressors and job performance (Gilboa et al., 2008).

This study uses a sample of Spanish workers to test its hypotheses. According to the literature on national cultural differences (Hofstede, 1984; Hofstede, Hofstede, & Minkov, 2010), Spain is more collectivistic and less indulgent than the U.S., where most relevant studies on workplace deviant behavior have been conducted. In collectivistic societies, aggressive behavior such as intimidation is likely to be avoided, as people place a higher value on social harmony and thus have a tendency to perceive aggressive behavior as a threat (Forbes, Zhang, Doroszewicz, & Haas, 2009). For indulgence, people in less indulgent societies are more likely to control their desires and impulses. Therefore, in a collectivistic and less indulgent society such as Spain, job stressors may be less likely to result in the use of intimidation than in individualistic and indulgent societies such as the U.S. Prior study by Coleman Gallagher et al. (2008) found the relationship between job tension and the use of intimidation in an individualistic society (i.e., the U.S.). Our study made unique contributions by revealing that even in collectivistic and less indulgent society, work stressors can induce the use of intimidation and it can lower the performance rating by the supervisor. Our mediation analysis offers empirical evidence for Coleman Gallagher et al.'s (2008) argument that in spite of the potential negative effects on their career in the long term, individuals engage in deviant behavior to alleviate the immediate demand in the short term.

5.1. Practical implications

This study provides several implications for practitioners. Previous studies have revealed that some stable individual characteristics such as Machiavellianism and psychological entitlement relate to the use of intimidation (Whitaker & Dahling, 2013; Whitman, Halbesleben, & Shanine, 2013). Our finding indicates that in addition to some individual characteristics, situational factors such as work overload also facilitate individuals' use of intimidating

behavior. What we need to emphasize is that managers need to bear in mind the overflowing negative effects of work overload. Specifically, work overload can have detrimental effects not only on his/her own physical and mental health but also on the people surrounding him/her through inducement of his/her use of intimidation. Thus, managers should not only conduct personality assessment to evaluate individuals' tendency to use intimidation but also put forth the effort to eliminate employees' work overload.

Additionally, our analyses suggest that a resilient individual can effectively cope with stressors without relying on the use of intimidation. This finding is practically important because the resilience measured in this study is a capability that can be developed through training intervention (Luthans, Avey, & Patera, 2008; Luthans, Avey, Avolio, Norman, & Combs, 2006). Given that anyone in any workplace has a possibility of becoming an intimidator, it is important for managers to develop members' resilience as a component of psychological capital that enables one to effectively cope with work stressors.

Our results are particularly relevant for sales management for two reasons. First, intimidation can occur in the human interactions with peers (e.g., short meetings, short conversations for information sharing, daily reports, etc.) that are included in the daily work of many salespeople. Second, the salesperson's role has become increasingly more demanding and complex, thus making work overload a growing concern (Jones, Chonko, Rangarajan, & Roberts, 2007). However, we infer that our findings can also be applied to workers in other jobs where daily human interactions are needed, or work demands are high.

5.2. Limitations and future research directions

Although this paper makes several important contributions to the literature, it also has some limitations. These limitations make our conclusion "with reservations," but they also pave some paths for future research. First, as our study did not examine the mediating variables between work overload and intimidation, we cannot conclude which theory is the best one to explain why work stressors increase one's use of intimidation. The general strain theory and revised frustration–aggression theory (Berkowitz, 1989) assume that a stressor generates negative emotion, and then the emotion induces deviant behavior. As an alternative theoretical explanation, we can assume that work stressors induce one's moral disengagement, which results in deviant behavior such as intimidation (Fida et al., 2015). By including both emotion-related and moral-related variables in the mediation model, future research can compare the explanatory power of each theory.

Second, our results showed the direct effect of work overload on sales performance. While the indirect path through intimidation suggests the IM effect on the supervisor's performance evaluation, the direct path may reflect the substantial effect of work overload on sales performance. This study includes only one mediator (i.e., intimidation); hence, we cannot determine the mechanism of the direct effect of work overload. To explore the mechanism, future research can include other mediators in the model (e.g., resource depletion).

Third, our study examined only one situational factor (i.e., work overload) that leads to employees' use of intimidation. There may be other situational factors that can be antecedents of intimidation. The circumstances that cause intimidation, as recently noted by Whitaker and Dahling (2013), are still not well articulated. In this regard, recent research (Restubog, Zagenczyk, Bordia, Bordia, & Chapman, 2015) has underlined that an aggressive culture influences the enactment of deviant workplace acts. In addition, recent research has confirmed that supervisors with a high level of ethical leadership are not susceptible to their employees' use of

exemplification as an IM tactic (Liu, Loi, & Lam, 2013). Future research can examine the effect of workplace culture and leadership on employees' use of intimidation.

Moreover, future research could benefit from examining relevant situational variables and characteristics of the target and supervisor regarding the effectiveness of intimidation tactics. For example, researchers can examine the moderating effects of other components of psychological capital (i.e., hope, efficacy, and optimism; Luthans et al., 2007). Liu et al. (2013) argued that the use of intimidation may not work in the context of ethical leadership. Thus, future research can empirically test their arguments.

We should also mention several methodological issues. First, we conducted a cross-sectional study, which makes it difficult to arrive at any conclusions regarding the causal nature of the examined relationships. In this regard, there is evidence that the effects of negative IM behaviors likely accumulate over a long time period (Whitaker & Dahling, 2013). Future research can conduct longitudinal studies to explore the accumulating effects of intimidation. To reveal the causal relationship of our model, experimental research would also be fruitful. Second, this study relied on salespeople's self-reported IM behavior and resilience. However, the self-reported measure may have resulted in some level of socially desirable responding. Thus, future research should consider collecting IM behavior and resilience ratings from other sources such as coworkers. For example, researchers can measure IM behavior and resilience through observations, peers' reports, or supervisors' ratings.

Finally, the sample size for this study was fairly small and included only Spanish salespeople. Although the use of a Spanish sample is one of the strengths of this study, we cannot deny the possibility that our findings are unique to the Spanish work context. Therefore, future research should replicate our findings in larger and more diverse samples. In addition, because of the concerns to response burden and an associated reduction in the response rate, we did not include a measure of cultural dimensions (e.g., individualism) in our questionnaire. Thus, we could not empirically examine the effect of culture. Future research can hypothesize and examine the moderating effect of culture on the relationships found in the current study.

6. Conclusion

Relying on knowledge of IM research, this study proposed and showed that work overload promotes individuals' use of intimidation and that the use of intimidation lowers performance evaluation. Moreover, based on Lazarus's transactional theory, this study revealed the moderating effect of one's perceived resilience on the relationship between work overload and the use of intimidation. In this study, resilience was operationalized as a malleable state. Therefore, our finding can make contributions to research on positive organizational behavior (POB; Youssef & Luthans, 2007) and provide insight into human development practice. We hope this study can be the first step to associate the research on POB and IM, which have been separately developed in previous studies.

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